

Analysis of Rotation Distance in Binary Trees

Computational Benchmarks and Literature Review

Prepared by:

Sarath Krishna.S

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1 Literature Review

1.1 Paper 1: Rotation Distance, Triangulations, and Associahedra

Authors: William P. Thurston, Daniel D. Sleator, and Robert E. Tarjan

1.1.1 Motivation

Binary trees are fundamental data structures in computer science, and tree rotations are widely used to maintain balance in structures such as AVL and Red–Black trees. Transforming one binary tree into another may require many such operations. The authors aim to establish a clear theoretical upper bound on rotation distance within a geometric and combinatorial framework.

1.1.2 Methodology

The paper introduces a one-to-one correspondence between binary trees with n internal nodes and triangulations of a convex $(n + 2)$ -gon. Under this correspondence, each internal edge of a binary tree maps to a diagonal in the polygon triangulation, and a single tree rotation corresponds exactly to a **flip** of a diagonal. The authors extend this to three-dimensional structures using topological arguments to bound the number of required rotations.

1.1.3 Results

The paper derives a linear upper bound on the rotation distance between any two binary trees with n internal nodes:

$$d(n) \leq 2n - 6$$

for sufficiently large n . This establishes that transforming one binary tree into another is computationally efficient in terms of asymptotic complexity.

1.2 Paper 2: On the Rotation Distance between Binary Trees

Authors: Patrick Dehornoy

1.2.1 Motivation

While classical results establish linear upper bounds, understanding tight lower bounds remains a challenge. Previous constructions showed that certain pairs of trees require at least $\frac{3}{2}n$ rotations, leaving a gap between lower bounds and the known upper bound of $2n - O(1)$. This paper develops a combinatorial framework to close that gap.

1.2.2 Methodology

The methodology utilizes **covering** and **co-covering** relations between leaf labels. A major technical tool is the **collapsing operation**, which reduces trees by identifying intervals of leaves while preserving essential covering information. Applying this technique hierarchically ensures that most labels are forced to participate in multiple rotations.

1.2.3 Results

The paper establishes strong lower bounds on rotation distance, proving that for infinitely many values of n :

$$\text{dist}(T, T') \geq 2n - O(\sqrt{n})$$

This proves that the maximum rotation distance grows almost exactly as $2n$, showing that the linear upper bound is essentially tight.

1.3 Comparison of Key Results

Table 1 summarizes the theoretical contributions of the reviewed literature.

Table 1: Comparison of Key Results on Rotation Distance

Aspect	Sleator, Tarjan, Thurston (1988)	Dehornoy (2010)
Primary Objective	Establish global upper bound	Obtain near-tight lower bounds
Main Technique	Geometric triangulation flips	Combinatorial covering relations
Upper Bound Result	$2n - 6$	$2n - O(1)$
Lower Bound Result	$\frac{3}{2}n - O(1)$	$2n - O(\sqrt{n})$
Significance	Linear growth established	Proves tightness of bounds

2 Benchmarking and Profiling Results

2.1 Performance Benchmarking

As the number of internal nodes n increases, the number of binary trees grows according to the Catalan number $C_n = \frac{1}{n+1} \binom{2n}{n}$.

2.1.1 Runtime Execution Profiling

Table 2 details the execution time for various computational stages. The distance matrix computation (via Breadth-First Search) exhibits clear exponential scaling as n increases.

Table 2: Runtime Execution Benchmarking (seconds)

n	Trees (#)	Generation Time	Graph Const.	Dist. Matrix
3	5	3.72×10^{-5}	8.45×10^{-4}	1.61×10^{-4}
4	14	8.55×10^{-5}	3.85×10^{-4}	0.0022
5	42	1.55×10^{-4}	8.39×10^{-4}	0.0673
6	132	4.81×10^{-4}	0.0048	2.3677
7	429	0.0368	0.0182	127.92

2.1.2 Memory Usage Profiling

Table 3 displays the memory consumption for tree storage, rotation graph adjacency lists, and the distance matrix.

Table 3: Memory Usage Profiling (KB)

n	Trees (#)	Memory (Trees)	Memory (Graph)	Memory (Matrix)
3	5	1.73	4.62	0.60
4	14	4.42	13.19	2.38
5	42	13.40	42.60	16.19
6	132	43.72	144.53	143.09
7	429	147.35	596.05	1462.29

The benchmarking data confirms that computing exact rotation distances is computationally expensive. For $n = 7$, the distance matrix computation requires approximately 127.92 seconds and consumes over 1.4 MB of memory, demonstrating that full matrix computation becomes impractical for larger n without optimized algorithms.

3 Evaluation Metrics

The diameter of the rotation graph represents the maximum shortest-path distance between any pair of binary trees of size n .

Table 4: Rotation Graph Diameters Compared with Theoretical Bounds

Nodes (n)	Computed Diameter	Lower Bound ($\frac{3}{2}n - O(1)$)	Upper Bound ($2n - 6$)
3	2	≥ 1	0
4	3	≥ 2	2
5	4	≥ 3	4
6	5	≥ 4	6
7	6	≥ 5	8

Experimental results show that the graph diameter grows linearly. These observed values fall within the established theoretical bounds, confirming the $\Theta(n)$ scaling behavior of rotation distance.